ERA 8

The Mexican-American War

1846 – 1848

The war · the Mexican Cession · the Wilmot Proviso

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did the Mexican-American War expand the nation—and reignite the fight over slavery?

KEY TERMS

Mexican-American War · Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo · Mexican Cession · Wilmot Proviso

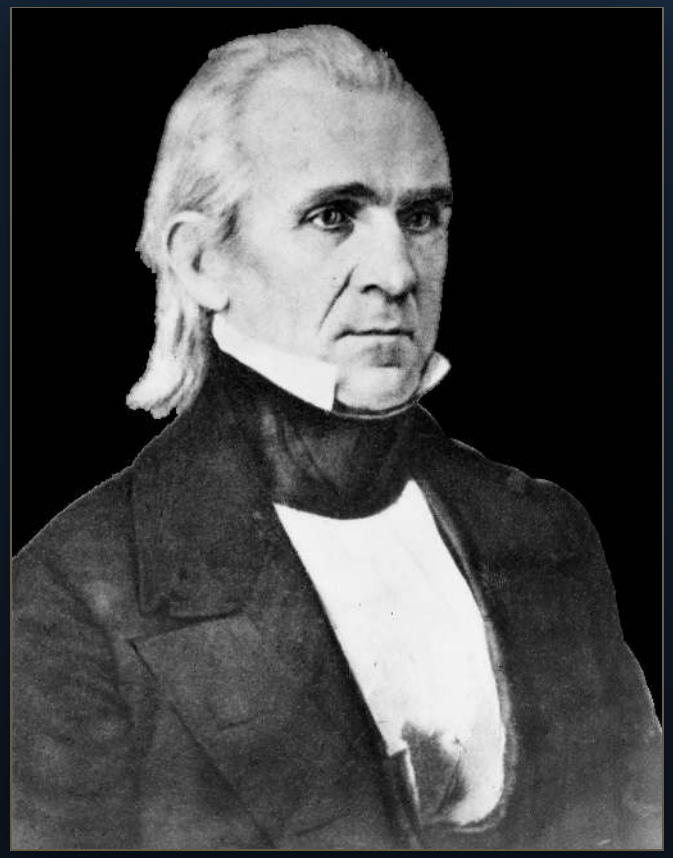
ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 5.3 · AMSCO Ch. 5.3

SECTION

The Road to War

President Polk & Expansion



- Expansionist **James K. Polk** won the 1844 election.
- Texas was annexed as the 28th state in December 1845.
- **Polk** was determined to acquire California and the Southwest, too.

How the War Began

DISPUTE

The Border

The U.S. and Mexico disagreed over the Texas boundary.

→

PROVOCATION

Taylor at the Rio Grande

Polk sends Zachary Taylor into disputed land.

→

CLASH

'American Blood'

A skirmish gives Polk his reason for war.

→

WAR

Congress Declares

Congress declares war on Mexico in May 1846.

SECTION

The War

Marching to Mexico City



- U.S. forces under **Taylor** and **Winfield Scott** won victory after victory.
- By September 1847 they captured Mexico City itself.
- The war was swift—but bloody and controversial.

A Controversial War

- Many **Northerners** opposed the war as a plot to expand slavery.
- Critics like Thoreau and a young Abraham Lincoln questioned its justice.
- The war deepened the sectional divide even as it was won.



SECTION

Victory & Its Price

The Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo, 1848



- Mexico ceded the **Mexican Cession**—California and the Southwest.
- The U.S. paid $15 million and set the border at the **Rio Grande**.
- The nation grew by a third—fulfilling **Manifest Destiny**.

SECTION

A Dangerous Question

The Wilmot Proviso

PROPOSAL

Ban Slavery

The Wilmot Proviso would bar slavery from all lands won from Mexico.

→

REACTION

The South Blocks It

Southern senators kill the measure.

→

RESULT

Crisis Reopened

The question of slavery in the West splits the nation anew.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

The Mexican-American War

1. A **border dispute** and **Polk**'s expansionism led Congress to declare the **Mexican-American War**.
2. Victory brought the vast **Mexican Cession** through the **Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo** (1848).
3. The **Wilmot Proviso** turned the new territory into a battleground over slavery—reigniting the **sectional crisis**.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The Mexican-American War

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how a **border dispute** escalated into a full war with Mexico.

ARGUMENTATION

Critics called it an unjust war of aggression. Using today's evidence, make and defend a claim: was the war justified?

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

Explain how the **Wilmot Proviso** turned a war of expansion into a crisis over slavery.

Up next — **Lesson 20: The Slave South** (cotton, the enslaved experience & resistance)